

IN THE DRIVER'S SEAT
Rohit Thakur, Chief HR Officer (designate) Mahindra & Mahindra; (seventh from left) Neha Anand, VP & Head, Global Brand, Mahindra; (ninth from left) Raj Chengappa, Group Editorial Director (Publishing), India Today Group; Poonam Mahajan, politician and MP; (12th from left) Gul Panag, actor & producer and Nalinikanth Gollagunta, CEO, Mahindra Automotive Division with awardees of the Mahindra Rise Drivers of Change event in Mumbai, Mar. 8

Photographs by MANDAR DEODHAR, HARDIK CHHABRA

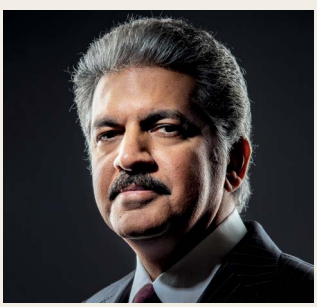
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achievers as the driving force in India's progress towards an advanced and inclusive society, celebrating their role as the embodiment of 'Naari Shakti', in steering the nation's journey.

The event was a celebration of women who "never left the driver's seat despite all odds" and featured women trailblazers from across India in panel discussions. Many women who were honoured through the Drivers of Change initiative live without the halo of celebrity, so this was long due recognition for their role in breaking restrictive traditional norms and having a transformative effect on society.

While Member of Parliament from Mumbai, Poonam Mahajan and former DG of Telangana State Special Protection Force Tejdeep Kaur Menon spoke about their journey in male-dominated fields, cellist Saskia Rao-de Haas and actor-activist Dia Mirza spoke about their journeys in art. Social activists Mittal Patel, Kriti Bharti and Virali Modi spoke about how their personal struggles—against physical attacks and molestation, for example—pushed them to launch welfare initiatives.

The panelists and awardees all spoke about how they were never deterred even while facing dire challenges and discrimination. "I never thought I was shattering the glass ceiling. I look at people as colleagues and not male or female politicians," said Poonam Mahajan, a two-time MP from Mumbai. Women, most speakers concurred, are required to work twice as hard as men to prove their mettle at work and be a caregivers at home. Industrialist and philanthropist Dr Swati Piramal spoke about the changes she brought



"We are celebrating women who have challenged social norms and made a difference across a wide spectrum of fields. The awardees have shown us what can be achieved by dedicating oneself for a worthy cause"

ANAND MAHINDRA
Chairperson,
Mahindra and Mahindra